Find the Cause, Not the Symptoms — Workbook

A Companion Guide to the Rotten Fencepost Principle

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This workbook is provided as a companion resource to the Rotten Fencepost teaching and may be used for personal reflection and study.

Notes

Introduction

Most of us have a problem we've fixed more than once. Maybe it's a disagreement with the same person about the same thing. Maybe it's a budget that never quite balances no matter how many times you tighten it. Maybe it's a health complaint that fades for a while and then returns.

This workbook exists because fixing the same problem twice is a sign — not that you're failing, but that you've been repairing a symptom instead of addressing a cause.

The Rotten Fencepost Principle uses a simple picture: a fencepost that looks perfectly fine above the ground while the wood beneath the surface quietly rots away. You can brace it, repaint it, even prop it up — and it will hold, for a while. But until you deal with what's actually happening below the surface, the post will eventually fail again.

This workbook will not tell you what your cause is. Only you can find that — it's specific to your life. What it will give you is a method: the same method taught in the video and the full guide, broken into honest questions and small, doable exercises.

Learning Objectives

By the end of this workbook, you will be able to:

- Describe the difference between a symptom and a cause, in your own words.

- Identify a recurring problem in your own life and name its likely symptom-level "fix."

- Apply a simple repeated-why exercise to move from symptom to cause.

- Complete a cause-versus-symptom worksheet for a real situation you're facing.

- Write one concrete action you will take this week that addresses a cause, not just a symptom.

Notes

Teaching Summary — The Rotten Fencepost Principle

On a working ranch, a fencepost holds up long stretches of wire fence. From above ground, a rotten post can look completely normal — the wire is taut, the post is standing, the fence looks fine. But below the soil line, moisture and time have been working on the wood for months or years. The rot is invisible until, without warning, the post gives way — and it often takes several feet of fence line down with it, because everything attached to that post inherited its weakness.

This image maps precisely onto how most recurring problems actually work — in health, finances, relationships, leadership, and everyday work. There's usually a visible "symptom" — the argument, the overdraft, the flare-up, the missed deadline — and a much less visible "cause," the actual condition that keeps producing that symptom.

The natural response to a symptom is to treat the symptom, and that isn't wrong exactly — sometimes a symptom needs immediate attention. But if that's all that happens, the cause is still there, still rotting, and the same failure will show up again, usually at an inconvenient time.

Find the cause, not the symptoms is not a call to ignore what's urgent. It's a call to also ask a second, harder question once the urgent thing is handled: what actually caused this, and have I done anything yet to address that?

Notes

Self-Inspection Questions

1. Think of a problem you have had to "fix" more than once. What was it?

2. What did you do the first time you fixed it? Did that address the visible symptom, the underlying cause, or both?

3. How long after that fix did the problem resurface, in some form?

Notes

4. When it came back, what did that tell you about the first fix?

5. If you're honest, have you ever avoided looking for the cause because the cause might be uncomfortable to face? What made it uncomfortable?

Practical Exercises

Exercise A — The Repeated Why

Write down the problem in one sentence. Then ask "why did this happen?" and write the answer. Take that answer and ask "why" again. Repeat at least four times, or until you reach an answer that touches something real — a belief, a habit, a decision, a wound, a pattern — rather than a surface-level circumstance.

Exercise B — The One-Week Action

Look at the deepest answer you reached in Exercise A. Choose exactly one small, specific action you can take in the next seven days that addresses that answer — not the original symptom. Write it down as a commitment, not a hope.

Notes

Cause vs. Symptom Worksheet

The recurring problem (symptom): _____

What I've done before to fix the symptom: _____

How long the fix lasted: _____

My "repeated why" answers (from Exercise A): _____

The cause I believe I've found: _____

One action this week that addresses the cause: _____

Notes

Reflection Pages

Use this space to write freely in response to the question: What is my rotten fencepost right now — the thing that looks fine on the surface but that I suspect is rotting underneath?

Notes

Action Plan

This Week: _____

This Month: _____

Ongoing: _____

Notes

Next Steps

This workbook is a companion to the full teaching, "Find the Cause, Not the Symptoms: A Rotten Fencepost Foundational Guide," available at https://keaupuniakeakua.faith/product/prod_find_the_cause_not_the_symptoms.

For the video this workbook was built alongside, and the rest of the Rotten Fencepost teaching series, visit https://keaupuniakeakua.faith/rotten-fencepost.

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